

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 5

The Vikings

A Calm Journey Through the Viking Age

✦ ✦ ✦

A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from Lindisfarne to Stamford Bridge, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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Scandinavia and the British Isles

Let's begin in the homelands and out on the western seas.



Places from the episode plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Coastlines are modern. The Danelaw label marks the general area of Scandinavian settlement in England; its borders were never fixed.

AT A GLANCE

- "Viking" first meant a voyage or a raider
- Most people in the Scandinavian homelands farmed, fished and traded
- Some went out over the North Sea in clinker-built longships
- Later, some settled where they had raided

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Places you'll visit in the episode

Ten places from the episode, from Lindisfarne to Stamford Bridge.

Lindisfarne · The island monastery raided in 793, long remembered as the start of the age.

Dublin · One of the longphuirt, ship camps in Ireland that grew into towns.

York · Jorvik, a Scandinavian town whose excavated houses and workshops can still be visited.

Edington · Where Alfred defeated Guthrum in 878.

Paris · Rouen · The Seine raids, the siege of 885–886, and Rollo's Normandy.

Hedeby · Birka · Busy trading towns of the Danes and the Swedes; Ansgar preached at Birka.

Oseberg · The great ship burial near Tønsberg, with carved wood and textiles.

Jelling · Royal mounds and Harald Bluetooth's runestone, claiming that he made the Danes Christian.

Stiklestad · Where King Olaf Haraldsson fell in 1030, soon honoured as a saint.

Stamford Bridge · Harald Hardrada's last battle in 1066, an end point for the age.

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THREE CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 793 to 1066

Three centuries of the Viking Age, one quiet step at a time.

AT A GLANCE

793	878	c. 1000	1066
Lindisfarne	Edington	L'Anse aux Meadows	Stamford Bridge

793	Raiders strike the monastery of Lindisfarne.
834	The Oseberg ship is buried in southern Norway.
840s	Ship camps (longphuirt) are founded in Ireland; Dublin grows from one.
c. 865	A "Great Army" lands in England.
878	Alfred defeats Guthrum at Edington; the Danelaw takes shape.
Late 800s	Settlers begin to arrive in Iceland.
885–886	Paris is besieged.
c. 911	Rollo receives lands on the lower Seine: the beginning of Normandy.
c. 930	The Althing, Iceland's assembly, first meets.
937	Brunanburh: an English victory at a site still debated.
c. 965	Harald Bluetooth raises the great runestone at Jelling.
c. 985/986	Erik the Red leads settlers to Greenland.
c. 988	Vladimir of Kyiv accepts Christianity.

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THREE CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 793 to 1066

The story goes on from here, slowly.



c. 1000 Norse people camp at L'Anse aux Meadows; Iceland accepts Christianity at the Althing.

1014 The Battle of Clontarf near Dublin.

1016 Cnut becomes king of England, and later of Denmark and Norway.

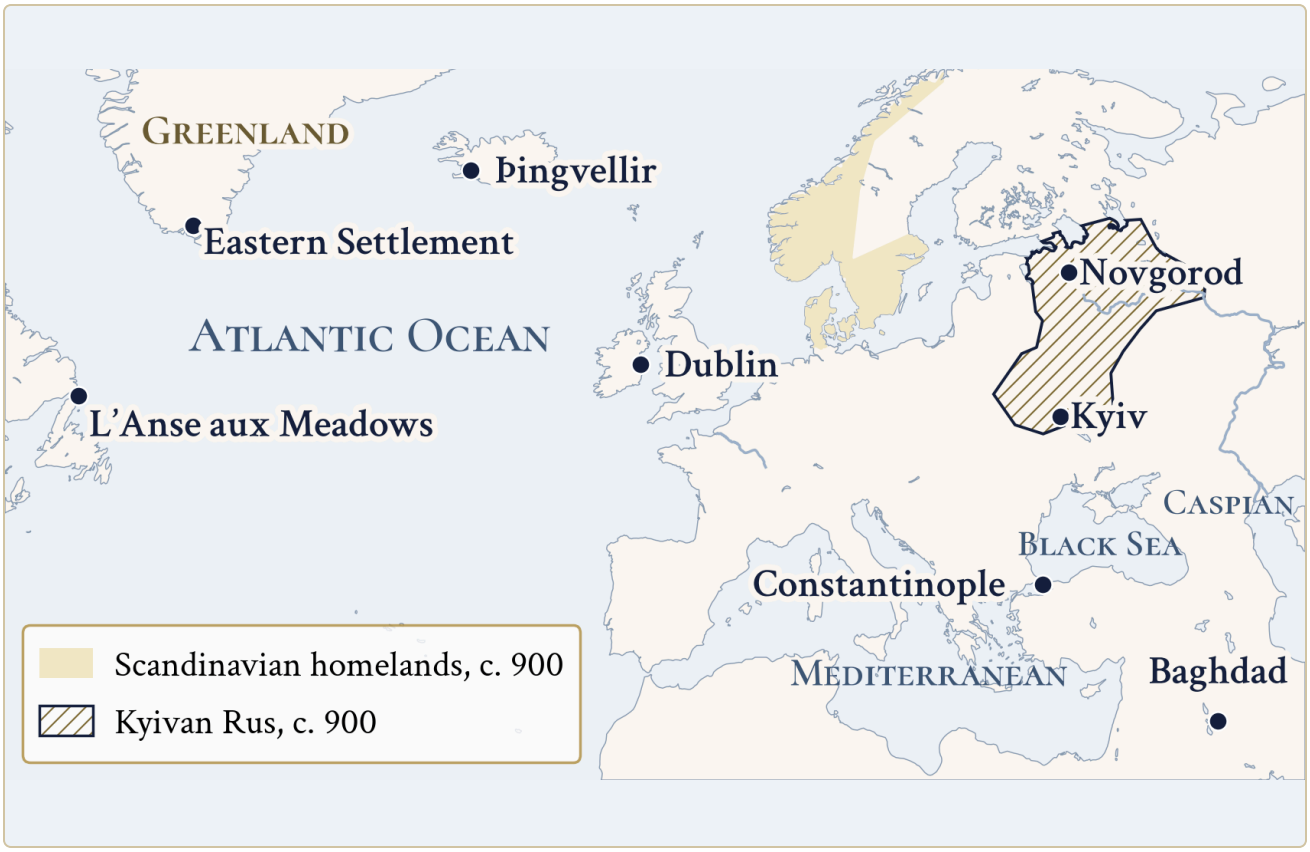
1030 Olaf Haraldsson falls at Stiklestad.

1066 Harald Hardrada dies at Stamford Bridge.

Early dates are approximate; some, such as Iceland's conversion around 1000, rest on later saga tradition.

From Vinland to the Volga

Now let's step back and follow the long roads west and east.



Approximate extent of the Scandinavian homelands and of Kyivan Rus around 900, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate. Norse settlers reached Iceland, Greenland and briefly Newfoundland, while Rus traders followed the rivers south, bringing Islamic silver dirhams north and later serving in Byzantium's Varangian Guard.

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People you'll meet

The kings, settlers and writers you'll meet along the way.

Alfred the Great · King of Wessex who defeated Guthrum at Edington in 878.

Guthrum · Danish leader who made peace with Alfred and was baptised.

Æthelflæd · Lady of the Mercians, who with her brother Edward won back Danelaw lands.

Rollo · Norse leader granted lands on the Seine around 911: the first ruler of Normandy.

Erik the Red · Led settlers from Iceland to Greenland around 985/986.

Leif Erikson · His son, who sailed west to Vinland in the sagas.

Harald Bluetooth · Danish king of the Jelling stone.

Cnut · King of England from 1016, ruler of a North Sea empire.

Olaf Haraldsson · King of Norway, killed at Stiklestad in 1030 and honoured as St Olaf.

Harald Hardrada · Varangian veteran and king of Norway; fell at Stamford Bridge.

Ansgar · Missionary who preached at Birka in the 800s.

Snorri Sturluson · Icelandic writer of the 1200s who wrote down much Norse myth, through Christian eyes.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, legend and history

A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The carved wood and textiles of the Oseberg ship
- Harald Bluetooth's runestone at Jelling
- The Althing, Iceland's assembly
- Islamic silver dirhams carried north by Rus traders
- Byzantium's Varangian Guard

LEGEND OR HISTORY?

Much of what we "know" about Vikings comes from sagas written down centuries later, in Christian Iceland. Horned helmets are a modern invention, the size of the Great Army is debated, and Clontarf in 1014 was not a simple end of the Vikings in Ireland. The episode keeps these apart from what archaeology and earlier sources show.





Artistic impressions of a Norse settlement and of longships in a fjord, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

Children of Ash and Elm: A History of the Vikings ↗, Neil Price (Basic Books, 2020).

The Age of the Vikings ↗, Anders Winroth (Princeton University Press, 2016).

The Vikings: A History ↗, Robert Ferguson (Penguin, 2010).

Beyond the Northlands: Viking Voyages and the Old Norse Sagas ↗, Eleanor Rosamund Barraclough (Oxford University Press, 2016).

The Sagas of Icelanders ↗, preface by Jane Smiley, intro. Robert Kellogg (Penguin, 2001).

Norse Mythology ↗, Neil Gaiman (W. W. Norton), a retelling of the myths.

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and podcasts

Museums & places

Viking Ship Museum, Roskilde: five ships raised from the fjord.

Museum of Cultural History, Oslo: home of the Oseberg ship.

Jorvik Viking Centre, York.

L'Anse aux Meadows, Newfoundland: Parks Canada's Norse site.

Podcasts

In Our Time: The Volga Vikings, BBC Radio 4, with Neil Price.

In Our Time: The Norse Gods, BBC Radio 4.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

Would you rather spend a quiet evening in a Norse settlement, or aboard a longship in a calm inlet?

"A sail lowered in a calm inlet. A spindle still turning in a woman's hand. A rune stone wet with rain beside a road."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE, AND FIND THE NEXT ONE

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙